

Q Do you see India gaining more importance in the global FOSS ecosystem?

Yes, of course. There are two aspects to this.

There are many alarms going off right now that, gradually, lead to the realisation that trusting proprietary software (and network) providers with our data is not a good thing to do. Some of these problems are global in nature, while some of them don't affect us yet.

Indians can gain more importance in the global FOSS ecosystem by pre-empting these challenges in our own society and solving the major problems that everyone is facing. A simple example is that if we can use and promote federated services on a large scale, it can offer a sustainable solution to this problem of websites tracking us and imposing conditions on access to our own data.

There are many other societies and countries that look up to us on how to solve these problems in an effective manner. Hence, by first using free software to solve these problems at our end, we can also provide leadership to everyone else and lead by example.

Finally, I would like to add that we need not just do things that are important for the global free software ecosystem. That could be a long-term side effect of the things that we do anyway. It need not be a specific goal.

Q Your favourite authors or books related to FOSS?

This is a very difficult question to answer since much of what one can learn about free software is not derived from books. However, I would like to mention three resources that can provide good starting points to others.

'Hackers: Heroes of the Computer Revolution' by Stephen Levy is an amazing book that details the history of the computer revolution and illustrates the 'hacker ethic' in the best possible way.

The source code, documentation and systems written and designed by D. J. Bernstein (DJB) have been inspiring.

While I don't use as much of DJB's software as I once used to, it has had a huge impact on my understanding of how software and systems should be designed and documented. In a way, his code is still poetry.

'Coders at Work: Reflections on the Craft of Programming' by Peter Seibel is a book about the thought processes and inner workings of some of the seminal hackers of computing.

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Using and promoting free software is a way to create equal opportunities for everyone – irrespective of their technical, social or economic background.
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Q If you were a youngster today (fresh out of college), what would you do differently with respect to FOSS?

I would focus more on writing documentation. I have learnt the hard way that to develop and service free software with excellence, documentation is extremely necessary—all the more if you're going to dedicate your life to working on free software. It is well known that doing things is more exciting for us than documenting them. But without documentation, there is no way to illustrate and explain what we are doing and to help others do it as well.

I would generalise and share a whole lot more of whatever I learn in the course of work. It is very unfortunate that though we (at DeepRoot) have built some extraordinary solutions over the past 18 years, we have not been able to make them generic or share them.

I would focus as much on building products as creating markets and sales

channels for them. This is important for any business, but it is especially important for free software businesses.

I would not waste any time pursuing venture capital — it is highly unlikely that you will find someone who will look beyond monetisation to truly understand the long term value and impact of free software, and invest in it. And hence, any time spent pursuing this option (at least in India) is a waste of valuable time.

I would devote much more time to participating in the local community and in user group activities. It was an error of judgement to prioritise 'work' at the cost of volunteering for the community.

Q Earlier, many firms and luminaries dismissed FOSS as a fad. Now, almost all greet it with open arms. What's your take on this?

Social movements are not fads. If someone has dismissed the free software movement as a fad, then they have only viewed it from a short-term or technological perspective. They have not yet been able to appreciate and understand the relevance and ideology of the free software movement.

At the same time, sometimes it takes time for the mainstream to catch on. Unless someone has owned and bought the problem, they can't appreciate the solution. So promoting free software as a solution to certain problems will not be received well unless someone has experienced or internalised the problem first-hand.

I think that's fine. It is, then, the responsibility of those who *do* understand to talk about it and create greater awareness and understanding about it.

Q What would be your advice to youngsters who may still be thinking about whether to build their careers in FOSS-related tech or not?

If they want to optimise for learning and experience the thrill of building things and solving problems, then I would definitely advise them to consider free